

BIG FASHION SMALL ETHICS

An exploration of the ethical compromises
of large scale clothing brands in America

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Abstract

The fashion industry has been a polarizing topic for decades now. Whether it is the wages paid to workers, the waste of resources, or overproduction, there is always some sort of negative connotation to the industry. However, when someone says “the fashion industry is unethical”, what do they mean? In what way is the industry unethical? And, how much do we know of the story behind everyday garments that hang in our closet?

As consumers, we often don’t associate these factors with our shopping patterns, but it is important to be thoughtful of what we buy and how we buy. According to Earth.org, clothing sales have doubled annually, while the average number of times an item is worn has decreased by more than 30% since 2000. While consumers cannot dictate how brands produce garments, they can make more informed purchasing decisions.

I chose to pursue this topic for my Master’s thesis because, no matter, we are all part of the fashion industry; therefore, we should all be more conscious of what we put on our bodies and exactly where these garments come from. America has been a major player in the fashion industry for the past 70 years post World War II (*American Fashion Through the Decades*, 2025), and an even larger player in mass production and overconsumption for the last 50 years with the strengthened trade relations between the U.S. and China (Fleshman, 2024). This is why I have decided to target my analysis on large scale American brands, exploring and comparing them based on their production levels and the ethical compromises they make in order to produce the items we all buy.

This project will individually analyze 31 of the largest and most notable American brands and target 2 main data points: size and ethics. Size will be evaluated based on yearly revenue, while ethics will be evaluated based on 5 key metrics: Supply Chain Transparency, Labor Compensation, Environmental Impact, Social Transparency, and Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness. Along with a performance review of each brand within these metrics, I will do a comparative analysis of these brands by utilizing a unique Ethical Compliance Index I have developed by taking inspiration from projects such as The Fashion Transparency Index from Fashion Revolution. The goal is to explore any correlation there may be between a brand’s size and their ethical performance.

Beyond this, the project intends to give consumers the tools and data necessary for them to make their own decisions of which brands fit their standards, and provide a more guided and autonomous consumer experience. My idea for this concept came from my own performance as both a consumer and a professional in the industry.

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Introduction

Fashion can be severely underestimated from those who consider themselves outside of it. As a professional that is part of the industry, yet surrounded by those outside of it, I constantly am reminded of the popular belief that fashion is nothing more than a form of art that is meant to be viewed and critiqued. However, a woman spends an average of 16 minutes deciding what they will wear on any given day (Tracey Lomrantz Lester, 2009). Furthermore, according to the Wunderlabel's *Fashion Statistics 2025*, the industry generates 1.7% of the global GDP (estimating 1.5 trillion USD) and 8.8% of global CO2 emissions. Whether a negative or positive one, fashion has an impact on everyday life, and it is important for us to understand what we are putting on our bodies, and how it was produced.

Beyond shining a light on the industry, this project focuses on addressing the increasing attention on the ethical practices within garment production, or rather, the lack thereof. In the past 3 decades, consumers have become more conscious of the exploitative processes within clothing production, and have begun to demand better standards (Benjamin Powell, 2025).

Wunderlabel's *Fashion Statistics 2025* also indicates that America plays a key role in this perspective as the most important import country for apparel globally with a volume of \$12.42 billion USD. This is why this project will focus on exploring American brands and their production levels. The goal of this analysis is to explore various data subjects related to production ethics of the largest and most notable brands in America (or American-based at minimum) and compare them to each other based on their size, in order to find a correlation between a brand's size and its ethical compliance.

Currently, there are plenty of tools that allow for ethical measurement of a brand in one way or the other, whether it is through environmental impact or labor conditions. Some of these tools include the Fashion Transparency Index, KnowTheChain, or the Carbon Disclosure Project. Taking all these incredible resources into consideration, this project seeks to provide a singular hub that addresses ethics in fashion as a whole, rather than parts.

In order to effectively explore brand data to determine ethical compliance, the analysis will consist of utilizing 5 different metrics that will measure a brand's ethical performance.

1. Social Transparency
2. Labor Compensation
3. Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness
4. Environmental Impact
5. Supply Chain Transparency

These metrics are a combination of existing structured data and a compilation of unstructured data to provide normalized scores. They have been carefully taken into consideration and meticulously measured in order to aggregate them into a singular index, allowing consumers to compare brands based on performance, and decide whether or not a brand meets their own ethical standards.

Project Context

The Brands

The choice of focusing on large-scale American brands came down to three factors.

1. The United States' Impact: As previously stated, America plays a leading role in the fashion industry as a consumer, making it the central geographic focus for my analysis, with the goal of catering to a larger base of consumers.
2. Notability: The project is intended to be perceivable by everyday consumers and fashion experts alike, therefore, it was important to narrow down my scope to brands that were large enough to be recognizable by all types of consumers, whether it was through personal experience with the brand or advertisement recognition.
3. Accessibility: In order to create detailed metrics for performance measurement, it was critical to focus on brands that were public enough to provide key data such as financial records, production quantities, and recognition from organizations such as the Clean Clothes Campaign.

With these factors in mind, I still had to determine what would be the factor that determined what brands were included or not, while still complying to the three factors above. This project is dense in data and analyzes extensive quantifiable data; therefore, I concluded that I needed to lean into the creativity of fashion, deciding on style as the determining factor for brand selection. Style allows me to present these brands to my audience in categories that are relatable and easy to digest. With the collaboration of Miguel Maldonado, a Mexican-German stylist with 20+ years of experience in the fashion industry, I narrowed down the list of brands analyzed to a mix of brands that cater to a wide range of audiences based on these style clusters: Casual, Classic, Outdoor, Seductive, Sophisticated, Dramatic, and Romantic.

Within the analysis, some of these brands do overlap style clusters, yet they all fit at least one of the seven clusters, which is the priority.

- | | | |
|------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| 1. GAP | 12. Ralph Lauren | 23. Tory Burch |
| 2. Old Navy | 13. Tommy Hilfiger | 24. Fruit of the Loom |
| 3. Banana Republic | 14. Calvin Klein | 25. Patagonia |
| 4. American Eagle | 15. Michael Kors | 26. Marc Jacobs |
| 5. Abercrombie & Fitch | 16. COACH | 27. Tom Ford |
| 6. Nike | 17. Kate Spade & Co. | 28. Urban Outfitters |
| 7. Under Armour | 18. Converse | 29. Anthropologie |
| 8. New Balance | 19. Hanes | 30. Steve Madden |
| 9. Champion | 20. Victoria's Secret | 31. L.L.Bean |
| 10. Levi Strauss & Co. | 21. Forever 21 | |
| 11. Wrangler | 22. The North Face | |

The Revenue Scale

While it was not the primary objective of this project, one of the central questions explored throughout the analysis was whether a relationship exists between a brand's size and its ethical compliance. In order to investigate this relationship, I incorporated a Revenue Scale into the project as a comparative measurement against each brand's Ethical Compliance Score. Within this analysis, a brand's size is defined through yearly revenue, as revenue reflects the scale of a brand's operations, market reach, production volume, and overall industry presence.

The Ethical Metrics

What can be construed as "ethics" can be subjective, as ethics can vary by socioeconomic class and region; however, when interpreting how a brand is ethical, there are various forms of measurement. Based on the available data and previous examples (such as the Higg Index), I have limited the definition of a brand's ethics to 3 components: transparency, environmental impact, and human rights compliance.

To successfully measure a brand's ethics in terms of the three components mentioned, I developed five metrics that combine and categorize the existing public data of these brands:

1. **Social Transparency**
The focus of the Social Transparency metric goes beyond what a brand's production practices are, focusing on how much of those practices they are willing to disclose publicly. This addresses the level of trust a brand places in consumers to independently investigate how their garments are produced and under what conditions. Rather than directly measuring whether a brand is ethical or unethical, the metric measures how transparent a brand is regarding the social impact of its operations and supply chain. The exclusive source for this metric is *The Fashion Transparency Index* by Fashion Revolution, one of the most widely recognized transparency-focused analyses within the fashion industry.
2. **Labor Compensation**
This metric measures the structural risk of underpaying garment workers within a brand's supplier network based on the geographic distribution of their supplier facilities. Due to the limited public disclosure of factory-level wages across the fashion industry, the metric was not designed to determine whether a brand is definitively underpaying workers, but rather to quantify the level of wage-related risk rooted within its supply chain. More specifically, the metric evaluates the gap between a country's statutory minimum wage and its estimated living wage across the countries where a brand's suppliers operate.
3. **Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness**
The Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness metric evaluates both the frequency and severity of human rights allegations against brands, as well as the degree to which

brands publicly engage with and respond to these allegations. Rather than solely measuring whether violations occur, the metric was designed to also account for corporate accountability once allegations have been raised.

4. Environmental Impact

The Environmental Impact metric focuses on a brand's disclosure of environmental policies, climate commitments, and environmental risk within its operations and supply chain. While environmental sustainability within fashion can be interpreted in multiple ways, this metric specifically evaluates how transparent brands are regarding the environmental consequences of their production practices and the steps they are taking to address them. The source for this metric is the *What Fuels Fashion? 2025 Edition* Report, which also comes from Fashion Revolution.

5. Supply Chain Transparency

Just like the Social Transparency and Environmental Impact metrics, the Supply Chain Transparency metric also focuses on transparency, specifically the disclosure of a brand's suppliers and production facilities. The purpose of this metric is to measure how willing a brand is to publicly disclose the structure of its supply chain, allowing consumers, workers, and organizations to trace where garments are being produced and under what conditions. The more transparent a brand is regarding its suppliers, the easier it becomes to investigate labor conditions, wages, and accountability throughout the production process. The data extracted for this metric is from The Clean Clothes Campaign Social Transparency scoring via Wikirate.

These metrics are not universal, but rather unique calculations extracted or designed to present individually categorized data that comes together to form a singular index that compares all the brands of this analysis, in order to provide a clear narrative of production values and ethics.

The Ethical Compliance Index

The Ethical Compliance Index is the culmination of the 5 metrics and the focal point of this project. It brings together 5 different normalized scores to create a singular score that positions brands on a scale in order to compare them based on their ethical performance. While the Index was not built to serve as the determining source of a brand's compliance to ethical norms, it is a tool for consumers to gain a deeper insight into brands' practices to be autonomous of their consumer practices.

The Conscious Shopping Tool

One of the primary goals of this project was not only to compare brands through ethical data, but to make that information more accessible and applicable to consumers. While the Ethical Compliance Index provides a comparative overview of brand performance, ethical consumption itself is not universal. Consumers prioritize different values and aesthetics depending on their personal standards. Because of this, the project concludes with the development of the Conscious Shopping Tool, an interactive recommendation system

designed to connect consumers with brands that align with both their ethical expectations and their fashion preferences.

Methodology

The Revenue Scale

The revenue data utilized throughout this project was collected through a hierarchical sourcing process in order to maintain the highest possible level of consistency across brands. For publicly traded companies, yearly revenue data was primarily extracted from SEC annual filings (10-K reports) and investor relations disclosures. When available, brand-level net sales were prioritized over parent company revenue to maintain consistency with the project's brand-focused unit of analysis. For example, brands such as Nike and Converse were measured using their individually disclosed revenues rather than the total revenue of Nike, Inc. Similarly, brands operating under conglomerates such as PVH Corp. or Tapestry were measured using brand-specific disclosures whenever available.

In cases where brand-level revenue was not publicly disclosed, segment-level revenue or historical estimates from reputable industry and financial publications were utilized as proxies. This was particularly necessary for privately held brands and brands operating under holding companies that do not publicly separate brand revenues. These estimated values were only used when no direct disclosures were available and were selected with the goal of preserving conceptual accuracy rather than forcing uniformity through parent company totals.

Because revenue differences between brands were extremely large, using raw revenue values would have disproportionately skewed the analysis toward the largest corporations within the dataset. To address this issue, all revenue values were logarithmically transformed and normalized into a 0-100 scale using a min-max scale. This process maintained the relative differences in scale between brands while making sure brands with exceptionally large revenues did not overpower the comparative analysis. As a result, the Revenue Scale serves as a standardized measurement of operational size that can be directly compared against each brand's Ethical Compliance Score throughout the project.

Below is the final dataset for the Revenue Scale.

Brand	Yearly Revenue (Millions)	Year	Log Revenue	Scale Score
GAP	3,501.000	2025	3.54	47
Banana Republic	1,916.000	2025	3.28	34
Old Navy	8,657.000	2025	3.94	66
American Eagle	3,411.237	2025	3.53	46
Abercrombie & Fitch	5,266.292	2025	3.72	55
Nike	44,714.000	2025	4.65	100
Under Armour	5,164.310	2025	3.71	55

New Balance	9,200.000	2025	3.96	67
Champion	4,000.000	2025	3.60	50
Levi Strauss & Co.	6,282.000	2025	3.80	59
Wrangler	1,914.622	2025	3.28	34
Ralph Lauren	7,079.000	2025	3.85	62
Tommy Hilfiger	4,770.900	2025	3.68	53
Calvin Klein	3,964.000	2025	3.60	49
Michael Kors	3,016.000	2024	3.48	44
COACH	5,598.500	2025	3.75	57
Kate Spade & Co	1,197.100	2025	3.08	24
Converse	1,692.000	2025	3.23	32
Hanes	3,507.438	2024	3.54	47
Victoria's Secret & Co	6,230.000	2024	3.79	59
The North Face	3,703.400	2025	3.57	48
Forever 21	6,900.000	2025	3.84	61
Tory Burch	1,700.000	2025	3.23	32
Fruit of the Loom	5,400.000	2025	3.73	56
Patagonia	1,470.000	2025	3.17	29
Marc Jacobs	704.100	2025	2.85	13
Tom Ford	371.986	2025	2.57	0
Urban Outfitters	1,247.742	2025	3.10	25
Anthropologie	2,426.438	2025	3.38	39
Steve Madden	2,534.109	2025	3.40	40
L.L.Bean	1,700.000	2024	3.23	32

The Ethical Metrics

The five ethical metrics are a combination of structured and unstructured data that is categorized within them. A key factor to consider is that three out of five metric scores are directly extracted from sources that had previously developed normalized scores that fulfilled the goal of the evaluations of this project. The other two metrics were developed by aggregating raw data from specific sources utilizing machine learning.

Extracted Scores

1. Social Transparency

The scores for this metric were directly extracted from Fashion Revolution's Fashion Transparency Index 2023. The Fashion Transparency Index evaluates major global fashion brands based on the amount of information they publicly disclose regarding their social and environmental policies, governance, supply chain practices, and

human rights commitments. Unlike traditional sustainability rankings, the Index does not measure whether a brand is sustainable itself, but rather how transparent it is about its practices and impacts.

The methodology of the Fashion Transparency Index is based on a questionnaire consisting of hundreds of indicators divided across multiple categories related to transparency within the fashion industry. Brands are scored on publicly available information only, meaning that data must be accessible through sources such as annual reports, sustainability reports, supplier lists, corporate websites, or public policy documents in order to receive points. Information privately shared with Fashion Revolution is not counted toward final scores.

The Index evaluates brands across five major areas:

- Policies and Commitments
- Governance
- Traceability
- Know, Show & Fix
- Spotlight Issues

These categories collectively measure how transparent brands are regarding topics such as supplier disclosure, purchasing practices, labor conditions, grievance mechanisms, living wages, environmental policies, waste production, and human rights due diligence. Brands receive a final transparency score ranging from 0 to 100 based on the quantity and specificity of publicly disclosed information.

The purpose of utilizing the Fashion Transparency Index within this project is not to interpret transparency as a direct confirmation of ethical compliance, but rather as an indication of a brand's willingness to publicly disclose information regarding its operations and supply chain. Transparency alone does not guarantee ethical production; however, a lack of transparency significantly limits the ability of consumers, researchers, workers, and advocacy organizations to investigate a brand's practices and hold companies accountable.

2. Environmental Impact

The scores for this metric were directly extracted from Fashion Revolution's *What Fuels Fashion? 2025* report. The report evaluates major fashion brands based on the disclosure of climate and energy-related policies, practices, targets, and impacts throughout both their direct operations and supply chains. Similar to the Fashion Transparency Index, the report focuses on public disclosure rather than independently verifying whether brands are environmentally sustainable in practice.

The methodology of the What Fuels Fashion? report is centered on analyzing publicly available disclosures related to climate accountability and decarbonization efforts within the fashion industry. Brands are evaluated based on the extent to which they disclose measurable information regarding greenhouse gas emissions, renewable energy usage, supply chain emissions, decarbonization targets, coal phase-out commitments, production volumes, and environmental risk management practices.

The report specifically emphasizes supply chain emissions due to the fashion industry's dependence on outsourced manufacturing and energy-intensive production processes. As a result, brands receive higher scores when they disclose concrete data regarding emissions across all stages of production, establish

measurable reduction targets, and provide evidence of implementation strategies rather than broad sustainability statements.

The final scores are normalized into a percentage scale that reflects the level of environmental disclosure and climate accountability demonstrated by each brand. Within this project, these scores are utilized as an environmental transparency indicator rather than a direct measurement of environmental sustainability itself. The metric is intended to evaluate how openly brands communicate the environmental consequences of their operations and whether they provide measurable evidence regarding their commitments and impacts related to climate.

3. Supply Chain Transparency

The scores for this metric were directly extracted from the Clean Clothes Campaign Supply Chain Transparency Score on WikiRate. The metric is part of the Clean Clothes Campaign's broader Fashion Checker project, which focuses on investigating wages and transparency practices within apparel supply chains. According to the project, the goal of the Transparency Tool is to identify the gap between brands' public commitments regarding labor practices and the actual conditions workers experience within supplier facilities.

The methodology utilized by the Clean Clothes Campaign focuses entirely on the level of supplier disclosure made publicly available by brands. Brands are scored based on how detailed and accessible their supplier information is. A brand receives the lowest score if it does not disclose supplier information whatsoever, while higher scores are given as brands provide more detailed facility data. These disclosures include supplier facility names, addresses, parent companies, product or service types, and whether the information is available in machine-readable formats such as CSV, Excel, or JSON files. The highest possible score is awarded to brands that additionally disclose facility-level wage data alongside their supplier lists.

The scoring structure utilized by the Clean Clothes Campaign is as follows:

- 1 Star: No supplier disclosure
- 2 Stars: Disclosure of facility names and addresses
- 3 Stars: Disclosure of facility names, addresses, parent company, and product/service type
- 4 Stars: Disclosure of all previous information in a machine-readable format
- 5 Stars: Disclosure of all previous information alongside facility-level wage disclosures

The Clean Clothes Campaign then converts these transparency levels into a normalized point scale hosted through WikiRate for compatibility across different sustainability frameworks. The methodology places emphasis on accessibility and usability of supplier information rather than solely the existence of disclosure. This distinction is important because Supply Chain Transparency is not only about making supplier lists public, but about making the data usable for workers' organizations, researchers, and consumers attempting to investigate labor practices and hold brands accountable.

Unlike the previous two metrics, the scores extracted from this source were not previously processed on a normalized 0-100 scale. The Transparency Tool from this source represents scores on a 4 point scale, which was then transformed into a 10 point scale by Wikirate's servers to be compatible with other assessment frameworks

hosted on Wikirate; in this case, 1 point translated to 2.5 points. When transferring these scores to my dataset, I translated Wikirate's 10 point scale to a 100 point scale, translating 2.5 to 25.

Developed Scores

4. Labor Compensation

To construct the metric, supplier relationship data was first extracted through Wikirate's API using Python within a Jupyter Notebook environment. The extraction relied on Wikirate's "Commons + Supplied By" relationship metric, which aggregates brand supplier disclosures from multiple public sources into a unified supplier relationship database. Through the API, supplier-facility associations tied to each brand included in the analysis were collected alongside facility identifiers, relationship types, and disclosure years.

Once supplier relationships were extracted, supplier profile data was pulled through Wikirate's company profile endpoints using each facility's unique Wikirate identifier. This process allowed for the extraction of supplier headquarters locations, which were subsequently normalized into a country-level geographic dataset. The resulting supplier network database consisted of more than 12,000 supplier-brand relationships and over 6,000 unique supplier facilities distributed across multiple production regions.

Country-level wage data was then manually compiled through WageIndicator and the Valuing Impact 2023-2024 dataset. WageIndicator provided the monthly minimum wage per country, with some countries having a standard and national minimum wage, and others differentiating wages depending on industry, profession, and region. In these cases, the lowest wage within production, manual labor or garment work was selected in order to estimate the worst-case scenario. Valuing Impact's dataset provided the monthly living wage for countries at different levels based on geographic location within the country, marital status, and dependents. For this analysis, the living wage selected was that of a single worker, with no dependents, and living in an urban area.

After both datasets were standardized and normalized within the Jupyter Notebook environment, supplier countries were merged with the WageIndicator and Valuing Impact datasets to calculate country-level labor risk scores. To quantify wage-related labor risk, a wage ratio was calculated for each country using the following formula:

$$\text{Wage Ratio} = \text{Living Wage} \div \text{Minimum Wage}$$

This ratio captures the degree to which statutory wages are capable of meeting estimated living standards within each country. Countries where minimum wages closely matched or exceeded living wages produced ratios closer to 1, indicating lower structural wage risk. Conversely, countries where minimum wages fell substantially below living wages produced lower ratios, indicating greater risk of wage insufficiency for workers.

The wage ratio was then inverted into a country risk score through the following calculation:

$$\text{Country Risk} = 1 - \text{Wage Ratio}$$

Through this transformation, countries with larger gaps between minimum and living wages generated higher risk values, while countries with smaller gaps generated lower risk values. These country-level risk scores were merged onto the supplier network database based on supplier location and aggregated at the brand level through Python-based data processing within the Jupyter Notebook workflow.

To construct the final Labor Compensation score for each brand, average country risk was calculated across each brand's unique supplier facilities. Supplier facilities were treated as equally weighted due to the lack of publicly available production volume data that would allow for more precise weighting by manufacturing output or sourcing dependence. Brands with insufficient supplier coverage (American Eagle Outfitters) were flagged as low-data observations and excluded from analytical interpretation where appropriate.

Finally, the aggregated country risk was converted into a normalized 0–100 score through the following formula:

$$\text{Labor Compensation Score} = 100 \times (1 - \text{Average Country Risk})$$

An important factor to consider is that Wikirate's database did include data for most brands of the analysis, but not all. Additionally, in some cases, the dataset only included data for parent companies rather than specific brands. In these cases, the scores for a parent company were equally applied to its subsidiary brands in the analysis; for example, Calvin Klein and Tommy Hilfiger hold the same score as they are both part of PVH. In the case of brands whose data was not included in the Wikirate dataset, in order to not dismiss them completely with a score of 0, and as per the instructions of one of my advisors, I applied the minimum score of the dataset (American Eagle Outfitters). I found this to be an efficient solution as American Eagle received this score due to its Low Data status, which would apply to the brands with no data available. Please browse the chart below to better understand how brands were measured.

brand	Unique_suppliers	avg_country_risk	avg_wage_ratio	labor_compensation_score	data_flag
Zegna (Tom Ford)	72	0.019124	1.023529	98.09	OK
Ralph Lauren	383	0.344099	0.713087	65.59	OK
PVH (Calvin Klein & Tommy Hilfiger)	1000	0.476633	0.563019	52.34	OK
VF Corp (The North Face)	1310	0.481065	0.56328	51.89	OK
Nike Inc. (Nike & Converse)	847	0.484484	0.568952	51.55	OK
Tapestry (COACH & Kate Spade)	46	0.488881	0.539014	51.11	OK
Kontoor Brands (Wrangler)	656	0.497036	0.528732	50.3	OK
Under Armour	195	0.500201	0.523884	49.98	OK

Hanesbrands	320	0.517829	0.50992	48.22	OK
Fruit of the Loom	451	0.527951	0.494852	47.2	OK
Patagonia	85	0.529009	0.48675	47.1	OK
New Balance	457	0.542914	0.516692	45.71	OK
GAP Inc.(GAP, Banana Republic and Old Navy)	876	0.583221	0.427099	41.68	OK
Abercrombie & Fitch	222	0.593819	0.415843	40.62	OK
Victoria's Secret	67	0.673925	0.326075	32.61	OK
American Eagle	1	0.750779	0.249221	24.92	LOW DATA
Champion	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Forever 21	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Levi Strauss & Co	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Michael Kors	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Tory Burch	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Marc Jacobs	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Urban Outfitters	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Anthropologie	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
Steve Madden	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA
LL. Bean	N/A	N/A	N/A	24.92	LOW DATA

Within the metric, higher scores indicate that a brand's supplier network is concentrated in countries where minimum wages more closely align with living wages, therefore suggesting lower structural risk of wage insufficiency. Lower scores indicate greater supplier exposure to countries where statutory wages fall substantially below estimated living wages, suggesting a higher structural risk of labor undercompensation within the brand's supply chain.

5. Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness

The data for this metric was extracted from the Business & Human Rights Centre and consisted of four submetrics: Human Rights Defender (HRD) attacks, other allegations, response requests, and response rate. HRD attacks refer to allegations involving violence, intimidation, or retaliation against workers, activists, journalists, or organizers connected to labor and human rights advocacy. Other allegations include broader labor and human rights concerns raised against brands throughout their supply chains. Response requests quantify the number of formal allegation cases in which a company was contacted by the centre for comment or accountability, while response rate measures the percentage of cases to which a company publicly responded.

To calculate the metric, all brands began with a baseline score of 100 points, with deductions applied proportionally across the four submetrics. The metric was

structured so that higher final scores indicate lower human rights risk and stronger accountability practices. HRD attacks were weighted as the most severe category and accounted for 35 points of the total metric due to the gravity of violations involving intimidation or harm against human rights advocates. Other allegations and response requests accounted for 20 points each, measuring both the severity and frequency of allegations raised against a brand. Response rate accounted for the remaining 25 points and served as the accountability component of the metric, rewarding brands that publicly engaged with allegations made against them.

Rather than assigning arbitrary point deductions per allegation, deductions were calculated proportionally relative to the highest observed value within each submetric across the dataset. This allowed brands to be evaluated relative to one another while maintaining the intended weight distribution of the metric. For HRD attacks, other allegations, and response requests, deductions were calculated by dividing a brand's value by the dataset maximum for that category and multiplying it by the category's allocated point value. Response rate functioned inversely, where brands with lower response rates received larger deductions.

Once deductions were aggregated, the resulting values were normalized into a final 0–100 score. Brands with fewer allegations, fewer response requests, and higher public responsiveness retained higher scores, while brands with greater human rights risk exposure and weaker accountability practices received lower scores. The final metric therefore captures both the structural risk present within a brand's supply chain and the degree to which a company publicly engages with criticism and accountability mechanisms surrounding labor and human rights concerns.

The Ethical Compliance Index

The Ethical Compliance Index is the culmination of the project's five ethical metrics and serves as the primary comparative tool of the analysis. In order to create a singular score that could compare brands across multiple dimensions of ethics, each metric was first normalized into a standardized 0–100 scale, where higher scores indicate stronger ethical performance. Once normalized, the metrics were aggregated into a weighted index designed to reflect the relative importance of each ethical category within garment production and corporate accountability.

The weighting process was carefully structured to prioritize metrics that measure direct human impact while still accounting for transparency and environmental practices. As a result, Social Transparency was assigned the highest weight within the index, as it is the only metric that encompasses the full scope of the analysis by addressing human rights, environmental practices, and transparency. Environmental Impact and Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness were assigned the second tier of weights within the index due to their direct relationship with human rights and environmental practices, reinforcing the values of Social Transparency. Finally, Labor Compensation and Supply Chain Transparency were placed in the third tier of weights, not because they are less important, but because they serve as reinforcements of transparency and supply chain operations, supporting the scores given by the previous metrics. The weighting system intentionally prioritizes measurable transparency and accountability because these are the most consistently available cross-brand indicators within public datasets.

The final Ethical Compliance Index consists of the following weighted structure:

- Social Transparency accounts for 30% of the Index.
- Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness accounts for 20% of the Index.
- Environmental Impact accounts for 20% of the Index.
- Labor Compensation accounts for 15% of the Index.
- Supply Chain Transparency accounts for 15% of the Index.

Each brand's final Ethical Compliance Index score was calculated by multiplying each normalized metric score by its corresponding weight and summing the weighted values into a singular composite score. This process allows brands to be compared not only by isolated ethical practices, but by their overall performance across labor conditions, accountability, environmental disclosure, and transparency practices simultaneously.

Below is the master dataset which includes the scores for all metrics and the final score for each brand.

Brand	Owner	Social Transp arency	Labor Compen sation	Human Rights Risk & Responsiv eness	Enviro nment al Impact	Supply Chain Transparenc y	Ethical Complian ce Score
GAP	GAP Inc.	48	41.68	37	23	75	44
Banana Republic	GAP Inc.	48	41.68	37	23	75	44
Old Navy	GAP Inc.	48	41.68	86	23	75	54
American Eagle Outfitters	Publicly Traded	21	24.92	83	28	0	32
Abercrombie & Fitch	Publicly Traded	33	40.62	89	14	75	48
Nike	Nike Inc.	50	51.55	60	27	75	51
Under Armour	Publicly Traded	28	49.98	70	6	50	39
New Balance	Publicly Traded	46	45.71	70	29	75	52
Champion	Authentic Brands Group (ABG)	0	24.92	63	0	0	16
Levi Strauss & Co.	Publicly Traded	60	24.92	71	26	50	49
Wrangler	Kontoor Brands Inc.	33	50.3	62	13	75	44
Ralph Lauren	Publicly Traded	54	65.59	99	28	75	63
Tommy Hilfiger	PVH Corp.	50	52.34	88	29	75	57
Calvin Klein	PVH Corp.	48	52.34	77	29	75	55

Michael Kors	Capri Holdings Limited	23	24.92	65	13	25	30
COACH	Tapestry Inc.	42	51.11	74	20	50	47
Kate Spade & Co.	Tapestry Inc.	42	51.11	86	20	50	49
Converse	Nike Inc.	50	51.55	98	27	75	59
Hanes	Gildan Activewear Inc.	38	48.22	97	37	50	53
Victoria's Secret	Publicly Traded	19	32.61	97	4	50	38
The North Face	VF Corporation	66	51.89	70	28	75	58
Forever 21	Authentic Brands Group (ABG)	0	24.92	73	0	0	18
Tory Burch	Privately Owned	1	24.92	96	0	0	23
Fruit of the Loom	Berkshire Hathaway Inc.	34	47.2	100	30	75	55
Patagonia	Privately Owned	40	47.1	86	23	50	48
Marc Jacobs	LVMH	28	24.92	100	15	0	35
Tom Ford	Ermenegildo Zegna Group	33	98.09	72	18	0	43
Urban Outfitters	Urban Outfitters Inc.	13	24.92	72	0	0	22
Anthropologie	Urban Outfitters Inc.	13	24.92	100	0	0	28
Steve Madden	Publicly Traded	13	24.92	74	9	0	24
L.L.Bean	Privately Owned	8	24.92	74	0	0	21

The Conscious Shopping Tool

The Conscious Shopping Tool functions through a filtering system consisting of two variables: ethical non-negotiables and style preferences. Rather than assigning consumers a singular “ethical” brand recommendation through a questionnaire or generalized ranking system, the tool allows users to actively define what standards matter most to them and filter brands accordingly.

The style preferences component was incorporated in order to acknowledge the role fashion aesthetics play within consumer decision-making. Since clothing purchases are not driven exclusively by ethics, the brands within the project were categorized into overlapping style clusters based on dominant visual identities and market positioning. These style clusters were previously used to determine the brands that would be taken into consideration for this project; they include Casual, Classic, Sophisticated, Romantic, Extreme, and Seductive. Because many brands operate across multiple aesthetics simultaneously, brands were

allowed to overlap categories rather than being constrained to a singular style identity. This allows the tool to function more realistically in relation to how consumers actually interact with fashion brands and aesthetics.

The Ethical Non-Negotiables component is directly tied to the five ethical metrics developed throughout this project. Consumers are able to select one or multiple ethical priorities, including Fair Wages & Worker Protection, Strong Human Rights Practices, Environmental Sustainability, Transparent Supply Chains, and Corporate Accountability & Transparency. Once selected, these filters function as hard requirements within the recommendation system. Brands that do not meet the minimum threshold for the selected ethical categories are removed from the recommendation pool entirely. The thresholds themselves are determined dynamically through percentile-based cutoffs derived from the dataset, ensuring that qualification standards are relative to the overall performance of the brands included within the analysis rather than arbitrary fixed values.

Together, these two filtering systems transform the Ethical Compliance Index from a static comparative analysis into an interactive consumer-focused tool. More importantly, the Conscious Shopping Tool reinforces one of the central ideas explored throughout this project: ethical consumption within fashion is not simply about identifying whether a brand is ethical or not, but about allowing consumers to navigate the tradeoffs between ethics, aesthetics, transparency, and accessibility in a more informed and autonomous way.

Key Insights

Main Outliers

The two largest outliers within the trendline were Nike and Tom Ford. However, these outliers were primarily the result of the normalized revenue scale rather than their ethical scores alone. Because the revenue metric was normalized relative to the highest and lowest revenues within the dataset, the two brands functioned as the endpoints of the scale, with Nike representing the upper revenue limit at 100 and Tom Ford representing the lower limit at 0. This caused both brands to appear visually exaggerated within the trendline despite the broader pattern of the dataset remaining relatively consistent.

Size v. Ethical Compliance

One of the primary questions this project sought to explore was whether there was a visible correlation between a brand's size and its ethical compliance. Going into the analysis, the hypothesis was that larger brands would perform worse ethically due to the scale and complexity of their production networks. However, the data revealed the opposite. While the relationship was not perfectly linear, the trendline displayed a noticeable upward trajectory in which larger brands generally scored higher in ethical compliance than smaller brands.

At face value, this result could suggest that larger brands operate more ethically than smaller ones, but in reality, the analysis points toward a different conclusion. Throughout the project, one of the largest limitations encountered was the accessibility of public information. Larger corporations, particularly publicly traded companies, are required to disclose significantly more information regarding their operations, supply chains, environmental impact, and labor practices. As a result, these brands inherently provide more measurable data for ethical evaluation.

This pattern becomes especially visible when analyzing the lowest-performing brands within the Index. Forever 21 and Champion were ranked as the lowest ethical compliance scores in the analysis, this can be mainly attributed to both being owned by Authentic Brands Group, a privately held company that provides very limited public disclosure regarding operational and production practices. Similarly, Tory Burch and L.L.Bean also appeared toward the lower end of the trendline while likewise operating as private companies with relatively limited transparency compared to publicly traded competitors.

This ultimately raises a larger question surrounding ethics within fashion production: if consumers and researchers are only able to evaluate what brands are willing to disclose, then perhaps the strongest measurable indicator available is not necessarily whether brands are ethical, but rather how transparent they are willing to be about their practices. In many ways, transparency itself becomes a prerequisite for ethical accountability.

Appendix

Below are the images of the visual portion of the project in linear order. To view the full project, please access <https://pabspadres.github.io/thesis/>.



BIG FASHION

How well do you know
the brands you shop?

SMALL ETHICS

HOW ARE BRANDS SCORED?

Learn more about how 5 metrics are
used to create the ethical compliance
score that rates brands.

Ethical Compliance Index

The ethical compliance index is calculated by multiplying
each metric score by its weight, and adding all five up to
produce a score from 0-100.



THE METRICS



Human Rights Risk & Responsiveness

Accounts for 20% of the Ethical Compliance Index

The scores for this metric rate a brand based on the data from the Business & Human Rights Centre, which reports on news and allegations relating to the human rights impact of brands and their response, if any. The scores were weighted and calculated using machine learning.



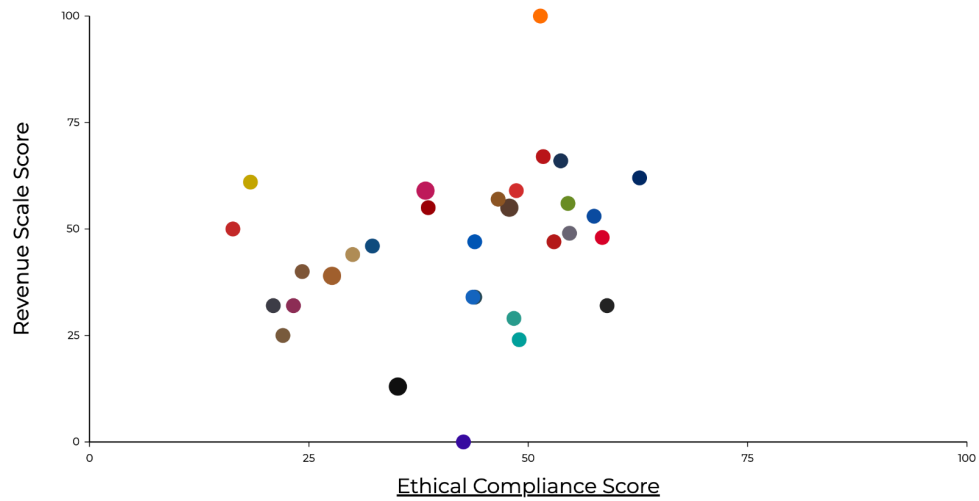
Your Score **7.5**/₁₀

[See the correct placement](#)



EXPLORE

Click on a brand to learn more about its scoring or scroll to compare brands by all metrics.



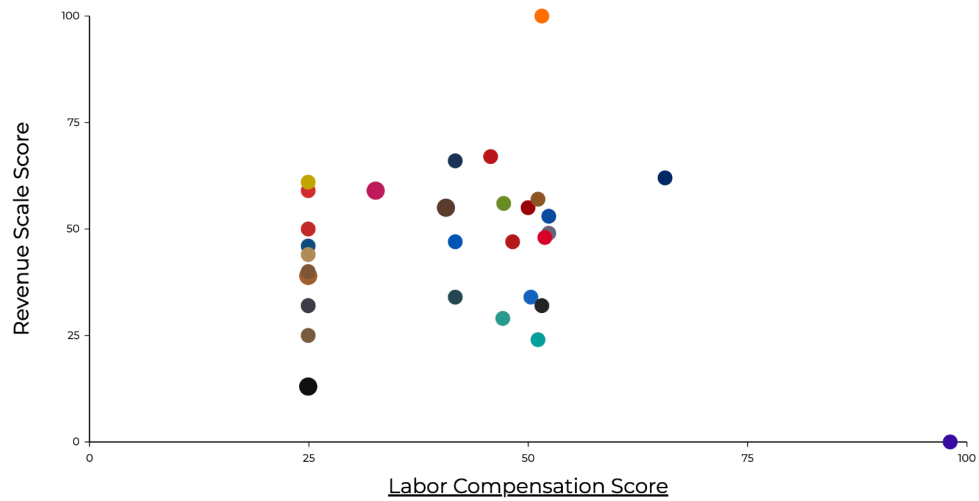
EXPLORE

Click on a brand to learn more about its scoring or scroll to compare brands by all metrics.



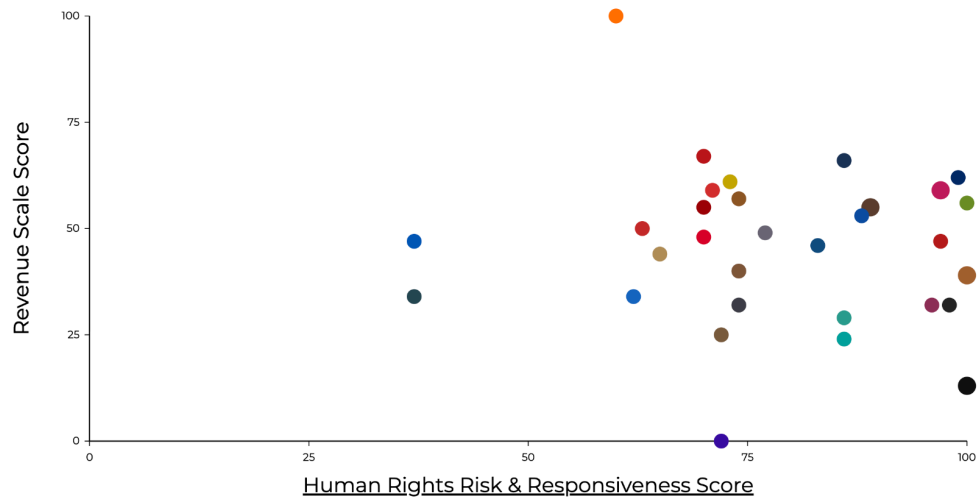
EXPLORE

Click on a brand to learn more about its scoring or scroll to compare brands by all metrics.



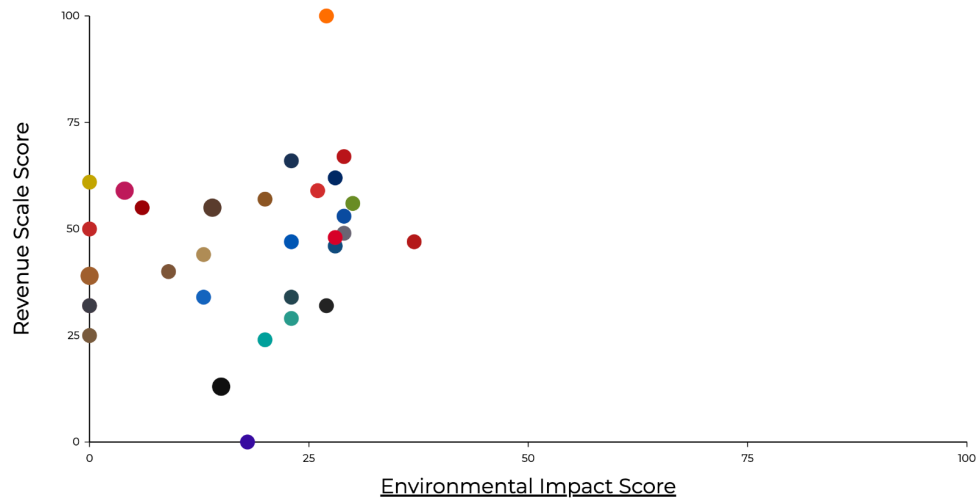
EXPLORE

Click on a brand to learn more about its scoring or scroll to compare brands by all metrics.



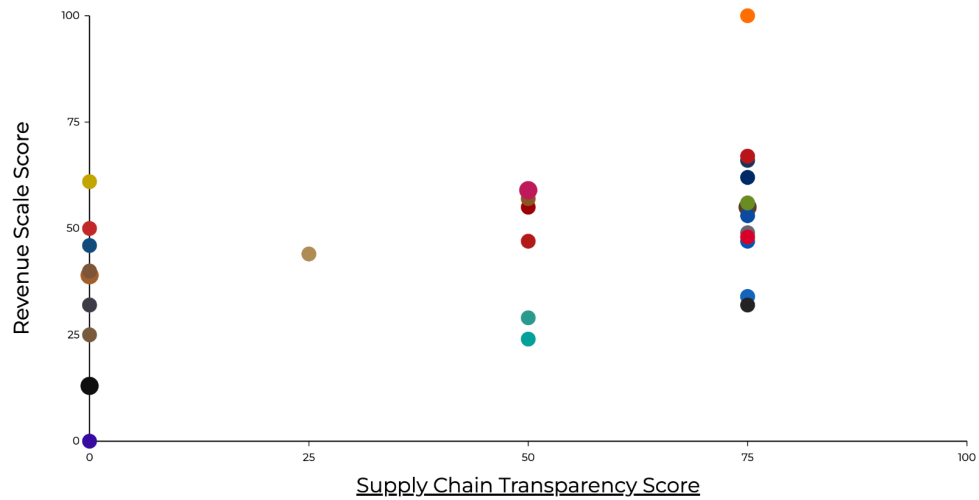
EXPLORE

Click on a brand to learn more about its scoring or scroll to compare brands by all metrics.



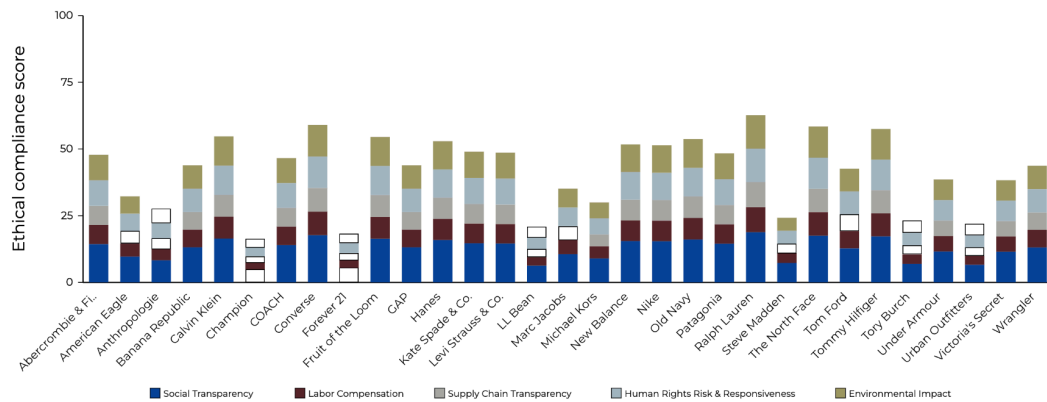
EXPLORE

Click on a brand to learn more about its scoring or scroll to compare brands by all metrics.



COMPARE

Click a legend square to filter metrics in or out. Click a bar or brand name to learn more about its scoring.

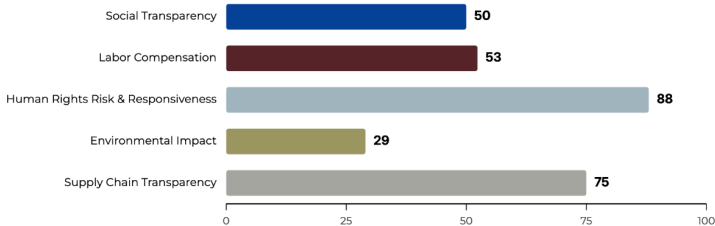


Tommy Hilfiger

[Brands](#) ✕

58_{/100}

Ethical Compliance



50

Social
Transparency

53

Labor
Compensation

88

Human Rights
Risk &
Responsiveness

29

Environmental
Impact

75

Supply Chain
Transparency



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